

PTI

sub-classification of SC/STs, AMU's minority institution status

› The ex-CJI's 2022 remarks during the Gyanvapi mosque hearings has led to polarising litigation over other historical religious sites

› Chandrachud's actions, including hosting PM Modi for a Ganesh puja, stirred debates on judicial independence

› A speech in which he admitted to praying before delivering the Ayodhya verdict also raised a few eyebrows

Yet, 2024 also saw Chandrachud entangled in the fallout of his earlier oral observation during the 2022 Gyanvapi mosque hearings. His remark that the Places of Religious Worship Act, 1991, did not bar inquiries into the "original character" of religious sites ignited a fresh wave of litigation. Cases like Sambhal, involving a petition to reclaim a disputed mosque site, and Ajmer Sharif, where the Sufi dargah's historical ownership has been questioned, have become flashpoints in an increasingly polarised debate. Critics argued that his observations risked reopening historical wounds, while handing a judicial veneer to politico-religious disputes.

By quashing the Electoral Bonds Scheme, the former CJI stressed that transparency is the lifeblood of any government

It wasn't just his judgments but also his candour that drew scrutiny. A speech in which he disclosed that he had prayed before delivering the Ayodhya verdict provoked intense debate. He also invited criticism for hosting PM Narendra Modi for a Ganesh puja at his residence. In a post-retirement interview, he candidly reflected on the fraught relationship between the judiciary and the political opposition, remarking that "the Opposition expects the judiciary to play their role". Unimpeachable as a principled veto on entangling judiciary in partisan conflicts, it showed him as a skilled hand at off-court jousting. Chandrachud's legacy is one of intellectual rigour and a fearless engagement with the faultlines of a divided democracy. In navigating these complexities, he left behind a judiciary both fortified and ever relevant in the nation's democratic journey. ■